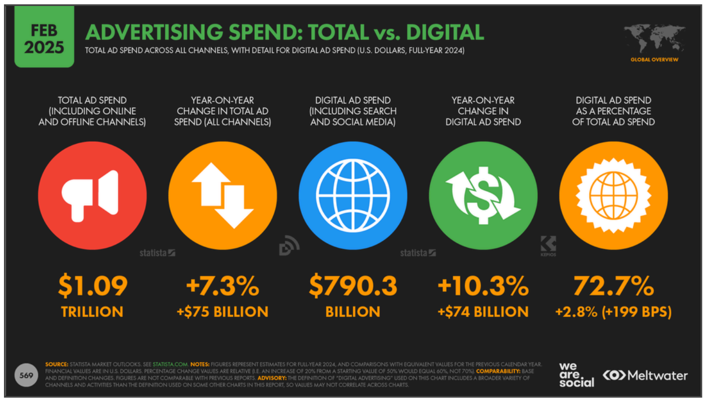
DIGITAL 2025: GLOBAL ADVERTISING TRENDS

5 FEBRUARY 2025 · SIMON KEMP

Statista's Market Insights data shows that the world's marketers spent close to **US$1.1 trillion** on ads in 2024, with global spend increasing by $75 billion – 7.3 percent – compared with 2023 levels.

Moreover, Statista's data indicates that global ad spend has increased by more than 50 percent since 2019, with digital



Ad spend vs GDP

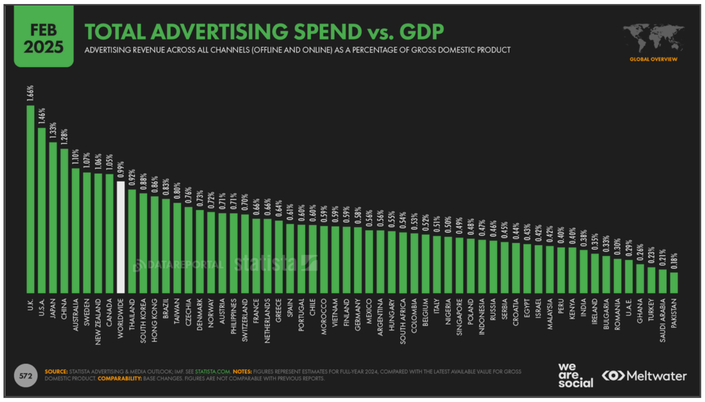
These latest figures suggest that advertising now accounts for roughly 1 percent of global GDP, although that figure varies considerably by country.

For example, Statista's data suggests that the UK sees some of the highest *relative* levels of spend, with advertising investments equivalent to 1.66 percent of the country's total GDP.

Similarly, ad spend in the USA equates to almost 1.5 percent of GDP, while Japan and China also see relatively high rates of investment.

However, at the other end of the spectrum, ad spend in Pakistan equates to just 0.18 percent of

Arabia and Turkey.



Changing channels

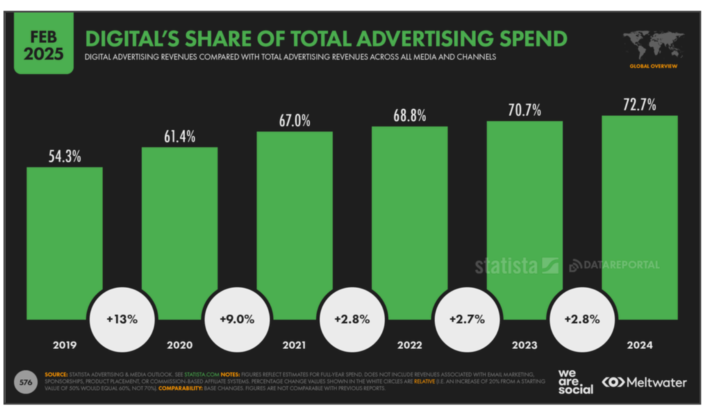
Digital channels now account for **72.7 percent** of worldwide ad investment, with online spend exceeding **US$790 billion** in 2024.

And these latest figures are testament to the dramatic shift in

As recently as 2018, digital channels account for just under half of global ad spend.

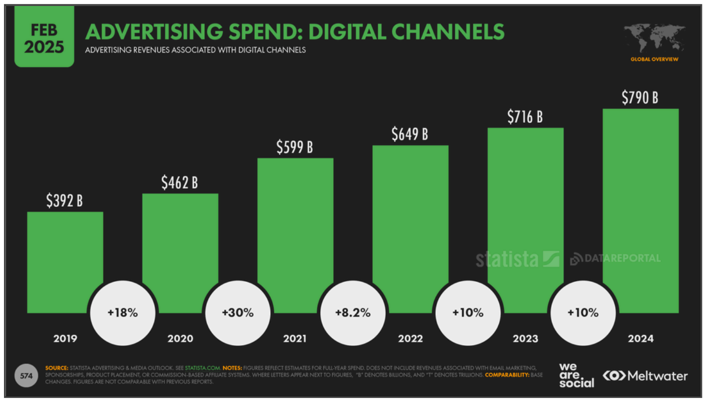
By 2019, that figure had grown to 54.3 percent, but share then jumped by a relative 13 percent in 2020, as Covid lockdowns drove marketers to embrace a markedly different mix of channels.

However, marketing spend didn't then revert to pre-Covid patterns after the easing of restrictions, and digital has continued to take share from "offline" channels every year since.



Absolute levels of digital spend continue to enjoy double-digital growth too, with Statista reporting a year-on-year increase of 10.3 percent (+$74 billion) between 2023 and 2024.

with Statista reporting a hefty 30-percent jump in total spend between 2020 and 2021.



Considered investments

The relative ease and cost of buying online ads may help to explain digital's rapid ascent, especially when we consider the role that self-service social media advertising plays for small and medium-sized businesses.

However, the imbalance we see between investments in online and offline channels doesn't actually match the role that each channel plays in delivering marketing objectives.

For example, while **GWI**'s research shows that digital marketing activities introduce brands and products to more than opportunities to influence the world's consumers.

Indeed, GWI's data indicates that nearly three-quarters of internet users – **73 percent** – still regularly discover new brands and products through "traditional" media like TV, print, and radio.

And with ad spend continuing to move away from these media, you may find that companies selling placements on "traditional" media offer increasingly competitive opportunities to reach the audiences that matter to your brand.

So, if you have the resources to embrace channels like TV, you might want to think about recalibrating your mix so that it reflects the realities of your audiences' behaviours, as well as the associated costs of achieving your objectives.

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Quantifying audience value

For added perspective, Statista reports that – across all channels, both online and offline – marketers spend an average of US$140 per head of population on advertising.

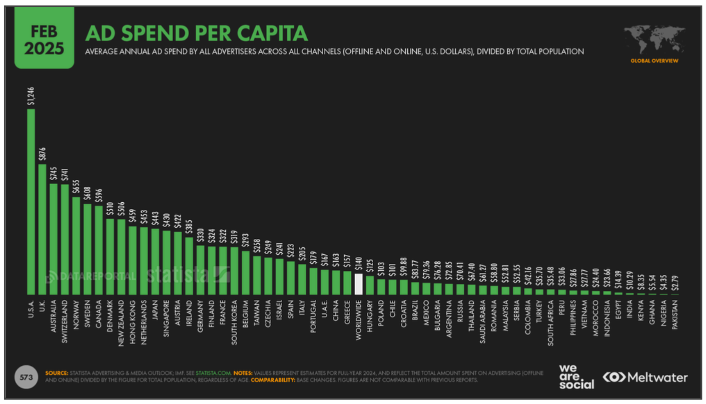
However, that average varies significantly from market to market.

The United States sees the highest levels of ad spend per capita, with the country's total ad investments equivalent to **US$1,246 per person** in 2024.

Per capita spend is also relatively high in the UK, where marketers spend an average of US$876 on ads per person, per year.

developed economies.

For example, ad spend in Mexico equated to less than US$80 per head in 2024, and the figure was less than $3 per person in Pakistan.

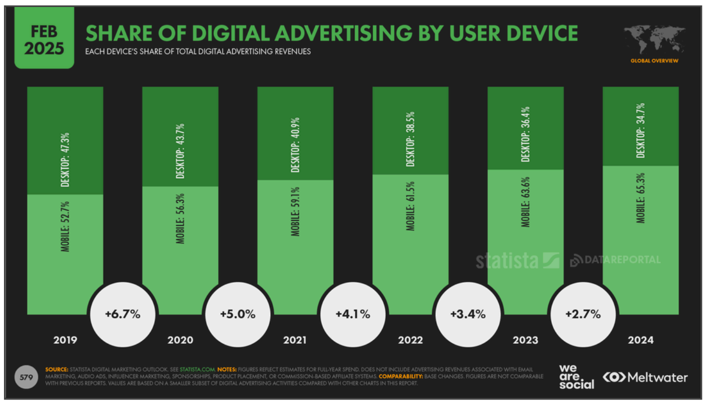


The state of digital advertising

Returning our attention to digital ads, data shows that the balance of spend across platforms and technologies continues to evolve.

For example, mobile continues to claim an ever greater share of spend compared with desktop, with Statista's latest figures indicating that mobile accounted for almost two-thirds of digital investments in 2024.

can see in our full report – but the overall trend is clearly towards mobile, with 2024's figure of **65.3 percent** already meaningfully higher than the 52.7 percent that Statista reports for 2019.

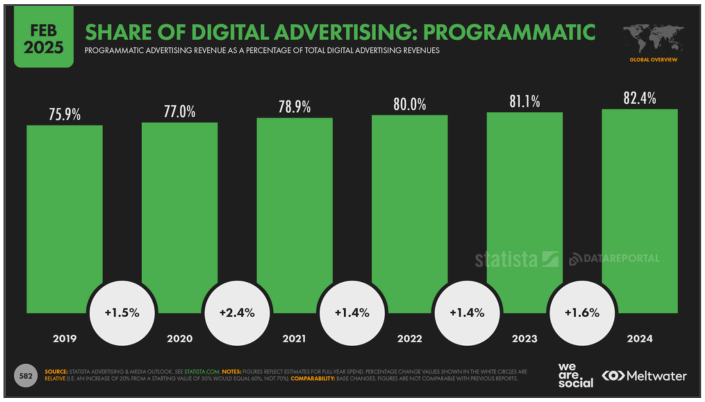


Programmatic ads

On the supply side, programmatic services also continue to gain momentum, with Statista's **Advertising & Media Market** data putting dynamic distribution's share at **82.4 percent** of spend in 2024.

That share figure increased by a relative 1.6 percent over the past 12 months, while 2024's figure is for 2019.

In total, businesses spent more than **US$650 billion** on programmatic placements in 2024, with that absolute spend figure more than 12 percent higher than the total for the previous year.

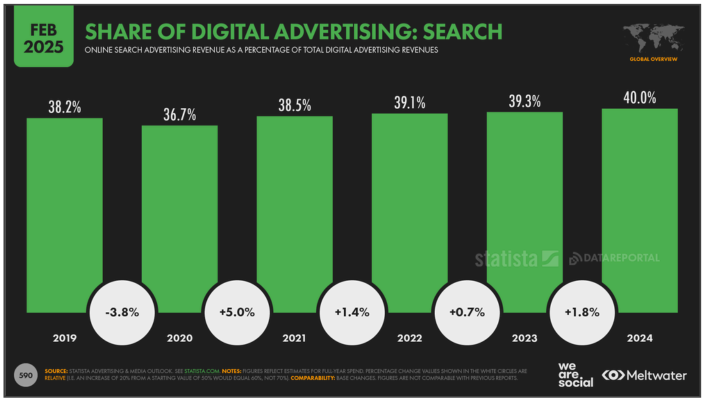


Search still finding favour

Search continues to attract the lion's share of digital channel revenues, with Statista attributing **40 percent** of 2024 digital spend to online search platforms.

It's interesting to note that search's share of digital spend dipped slightly after the outbreak of Covid-19 in 2020, but platforms like Google have seen their share of the digital pie increase every year since.

revenue during 2024, with that total more than 12 percent higher than the equivalent figure for 2023.

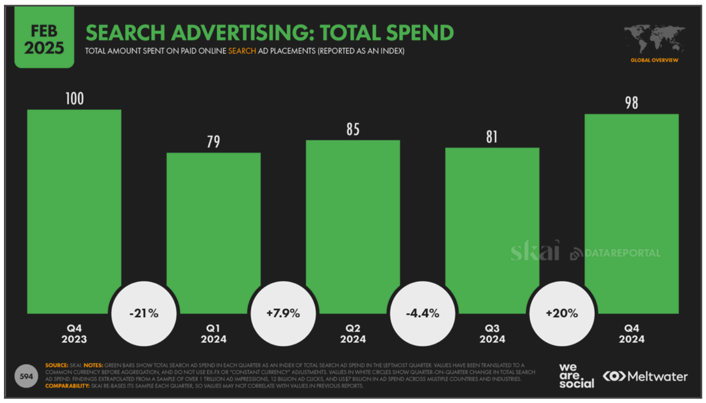


There are some warning signs in the data though, with **Skai** reporting that spend on search ads in the last three months of 2024 was actually 2 percent *lower* than spend in the equivalent period of 2023.

Moreover, the number of search impressions served saw an even bigger drop, with Skai's analysis pointing to a 14 percent year-on-year decline between Q4 2023 and Q4 2024.

However, click-through rates improved significantly during that same period, from 1.6 percent in Q4 2023, to 1.86 percent in the last three months of 2024.

clicks, which helps to explain why the average cost per click (CPC) only declined by US$0.01 during the same period.



Shopping around

Meanwhile, it's particularly interesting to note the rise of advertising on online retail platforms like Amazon.

Statista reports that online retail platform advertising accounted for more than 1 in 5 digital ad dollars around the world last year, with these channels claiming **21.2**

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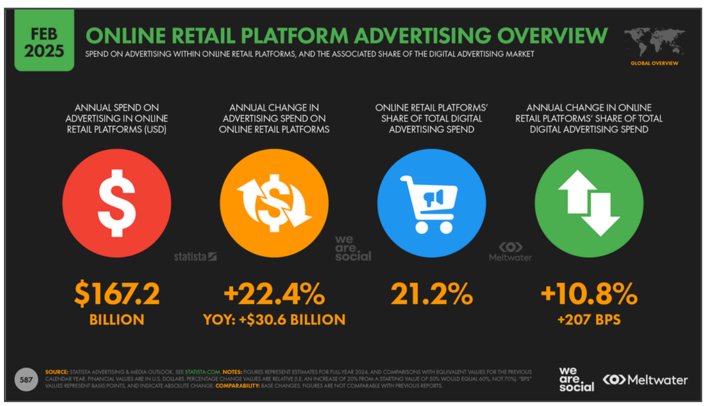
And for perspective, that figure is almost *double* the 10.9 percent share that these platforms claimed in 2019.

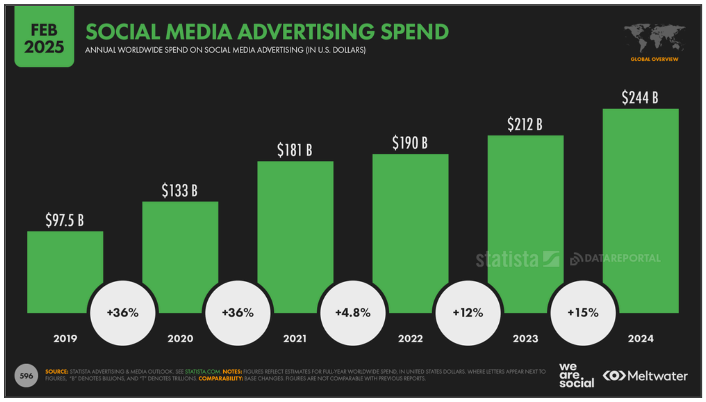
In total, Statista reports that online retailers earned more than **US$167 billion** from ad placements on their platforms in 2024, suggesting that this channel is increasingly important for consumer goods marketing.



Social climbing

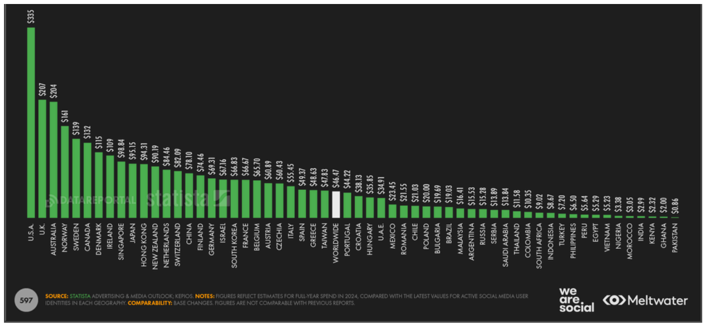
Statista's data suggests that 2024 was a particularly good year for social media platforms too, with global spend on social media ads increasing by **15 percent** compared with 2023.

Figures indicate that marketers spent close to a *quarter of a* placements responsible for more than 3 in every 10 dollars spent on digital advertising.



And if we compare these social media ad spend figures with our latest data for social media user identities, the data suggest that the world's marketers spend an average of **US$46.47 per user** to reach social audiences.

Once again, that figure varies meaningfully by country though, from a hefty **US$335** per user in the United States, to just 86 cents (USD) in Pakistan.



However, the latest data from Skai suggests that average social media CPMs slipped in Q4 2024 compared with the same period a year ago.

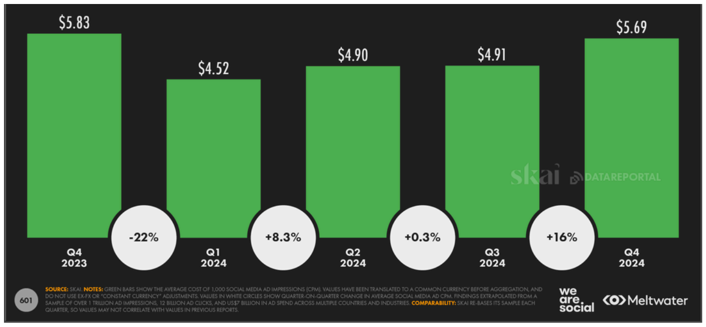
The company's analysis of billions of dollars of ad spend indicates that advertisers spent an average of **US$5.69** to deliver 1,000 ad impressions on social platforms between October and December 2024, which was 4.4 percent *lower* than the US$5.83 they

On the other hand though, Skai's data also shows that the total number of impressions served across social platforms in Q4 2024 was roughly 4 percent higher than the figure for the same period a year earlier.

And similarly, the company's analysis indicates that total spend on social media ads in the last three months of 2024 was roughly 2 percent higher than spend in the final quarter of 2023.

GET THE FULL PICTURE

This article is a *sub-section* of our **Digital 2025 Global Overview Report**. **Click here** to access the complete report, and to read our comprehensive analysis.



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